

Reflection on Biases

Ibelice Medina

University of Texas at San Antonio

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Dr. Trotter

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The definition of bias is prejudice in favor of or against one thing, person, or group compared with another, usually in a way considered to be unfair. As an aspiring counselor, it is important to acknowledge one's biases and self-reflect on why we have those ideas embedded into our minds. Taking the Race Implicit Association Test (IAT) allowed me to self-reflect on my results and challenge myself to allow myself to feel uncomfortable. The test stated that I was moderately faster at associating "Black people" with "Bad" and "White people" with "Good". Reading this made me uncomfortable because I was not aware of these biases or had taken the time to process these unconscious thoughts.

Being able to acknowledge that I felt uncomfortable reading these results is one of the first steps on becoming a culturally competent counselor. Although the test itself does not define one's character, it gives us the opportunity to become self-aware and take accountability for our future actions. As a counselor-in-training, the IAT results can help me become aware of my own limitations and why I am biased. By doing this, I can potentially explore ways to incorporate myself in different cultures for a better understanding of different ethnicities aside from my own as a Hispanic woman living primarily in a neighborhood that is not culturally diverse. The IAT can also be interpreted in a way where I can be mindful of the type of counseling quality I provide to my future clients. Understanding race biases helps to avoid microaggressions to diverse populations across mental health. Opening my mind and perspective to people with different life experiences than myself is important as it allows me to have an open mind about different points of views, and I am able to practice active listening to understand rather than to reply.

Ensuring a safe space for everyone regardless of their cultural background is essential for building trust and transparency in the counselor-client relationship. Emerging myself in different cultures, opinions, and practicing mindfulness can be related to multicultural counseling competencies. As a society, we have made improvements regarding advocating for human rights and equal treatment. It is important to keep advocating for minorities and to become conscious that there are different cultures with varied ideals, morals, and experiences. Although not that long ago, as stated in Chapter 5 in *Counseling the Culturally Diverse*, in 1989, Canadian psychologist John Philippe Rushton claimed that human intelligence and behavior are largely determined by race, that White Americans have bigger brains than Black Americans, and that Black Americans are innately more aggressive (Rushton, 1989; Samuda, 1998). It was approximately 36 years ago when a psychologist claimed that the intelligence and behaviors of humans are different from White Americans and Black Americans. Knowing that this happened so recently allows me to reflect on how much more work needs to be done on analyzing and reflecting one's own biases regarding race, ethnicity, culture, and gender.

The second IAT taken was regarding weight and my results suggested a slight automatic preference for “fat” people over “thin” people. I was a bit taken back with these results and although I might not be fully aware of this, I can have an understanding on why I would think this way. Growing up in my family's culture, it was frowned upon to see a thin person because they were deemed as “unhealthy” even though I was extremely thin growing up. Reflecting on my biases regarding weight will allow me to become a sensitive future counselor and empathize with individuals. As a future counselor, I want to be the best version of myself and help different populations. If I have prejudice against individuals based on their weight, it will not allow me to

grow and provide proper therapy. Taking accountability and self-reflecting why I have certain biases is a way to expand my mind and be mindful of my actions.

Lastly, the IAT test on career with men and women suggested a “moderate automatic association for Male with Career and Female with Family”. These biases are rooted in my household's traditional gender roles. Growing up, I have always seen my dad go to work and “take care” of the house while my mom stayed home with my siblings and I taking care of us. Witnessing this did have an impact on how I view men and women career wise. These influenced my biases on traditional norms and can work on becoming self-aware. To prevent these biases from impacting my profession, I will be reflecting on how to prevent gender stereotypes when a client is in counseling and is seeking career guidance. Furthermore, the skills I will be gaining through my counseling program will help me improve appropriate techniques when counseling populations from diverse cultural backgrounds and perspectives. It is important to have an open mind and be mindful that my “traditional gender roles” are not always the standard to all cultures.

Overall, taking these three IAT tests helped me understand what I need to reflect and improve on as a person and aspiring counselor. To become culturally competent, there are strategies that can be put in place. One of the techniques I have thought of throughout my reflection has been to integrate myself in other cultures and allow myself to learn with an open mind. The second technique is actively seeking supervision to challenge myself to new points of views that I have not listened to before. Lastly, is being self-aware that I do have biases that can be controversial with future clients and unintentionally do more damage than good to those seeking therapy. This is why I strive to be mindful, self-aware, and a kind counselor to all clients regardless of their gender, race, ethnicity, and/or culture. My job will be to provide a safe space.

References

Sue, D. W., Sue, D., Neville, H. A., & Smith, L. (2022). Counseling the culturally diverse: Theory and practice (9th ed.). Wiley.